BOOKS ▼

INSIDE THE INDIRA YEARS

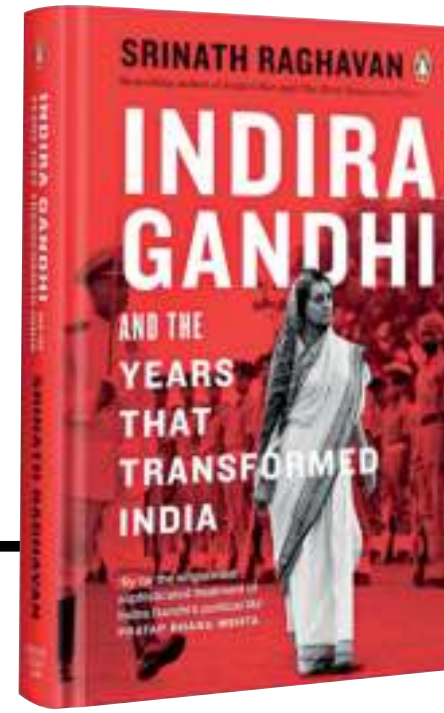
A NEW BOOK BY HISTORIAN SRINATH RAGHAVAN CHARTS INDIRA GANDHI'S POLITICAL CAREER AND HOW IT SHAPED POSTCOLONIAL INDIA

It is not easy to find words that will do justice to Srinath Raghavan's book on how the decisions that Indira Gandhi took during her two stints as India's prime minister—from 1966 till 1977, and 1980 till October 31, 1984—shaped India's development as a democracy. Mrs Gandhi became PM when the country was in the grip of an unprecedented crisis. India had run out of foreign exchange a decade earlier, suffered a severe failure of the southwest monsoons in 1965, and a second failure in 1966 was on the way.

The decisions she had to take—a 57 per cent devaluation of the rupee, and asking the US to back a loan of almost a billion dollars—put her at odds with the seasoned leaders of the organisational wing of the party, known as the Syndicate.

These leaders, who later became the Congress (O), did not understand the magnitude of the crisis and resented her taking critical decisions without consulting them. This led to the party splitting in 1969. Raghavan's description of how and why this took place—based on a penetrating study of recently declassified documents and Mrs Gandhi's personal correspondence—will probably never be bettered. This is also true of his analysis of Mrs Gandhi's reasons for declaring the Emergency in 1975. Although he disapproves of her decision, he is scrupulous in describing the chain of events, beginning with the drought of 1972, and culminating in the assassination of railway minister L.N. Mishra in Bihar in January 1975.

Of infinite value is Raghavan's detailed description of the correspondence between Mrs Gandhi and her principal advisors, and her correspondence with various opposition leaders, particularly Jayaprakash Narayan. These highlight her keenness to work with, rather than against him. It was JP's failure to suggest a way to meet the students' demands without endangering the State's stability, and his admonition to the army and police to disobey "illegal orders" that pushed her to declare the Emergency.



INDIRA GANDHI AND THE YEARS THAT TRANSFORMED INDIA
By Srinath Raghavan
PENGUIN/ ALLEN LANE
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Raghavan's analysis of the four years of Mrs Gandhi's rule that ended with her assassination is less compelling. This could be because the documents and correspondence of this period have not yet been de-classified. Hence, Raghavan did not know that it was not army commander General Vaidya who instigated the army's invasion of the Golden Temple but the Western Command chief, General Sundarji, who persuaded Mrs Gandhi that 'his' army would clean out the Bhindranwale rebels in hours.

Nor did Raghavan find that, in January 1984, Mrs Gandhi had set up a 'high level' committee headed by her former intelligence chief R.N. Kao, to find a way to clear the Golden Temple with minimum casualties to civilians, and that this committee had almost finalised its plan when Kao was ordered to abandon it as the army had been given the job. That plan was used to drive Khalistani rebels out of the Golden Temple after they occupied it a second time in 1988. It succeeded after causing only 14 deaths. ■

—Prem Shankar Jha